

hosted in India for the first time. With seating for more than 1,500 spectators, the stadium's main pool, built by Italian company Myrtha Pools, features a mobile bulkhead that can split it into two halves when needed. At first glance, it may seem like any other pool, but every element has been meticulously engineered for performance, we soon learn. Hakimuddin Habibulla, Managing Director for India and South Asia at Myrtha Pools India Pvt. Ltd., reveals the detailed thought process behind its construction.

Unlike traditional concrete pools, this facility uses pre-engineered, PVC-laminated stainless-steel panels. "At the bottom is a reinforced special PVC membrane installed on the floor. It's not glued or fixed but laid in place and held down by the water pressure. The membrane has a reinforced fibreglass mesh inside, so it's very strong," explains Hakim, as he is fondly called.

Even the placement of the water inlets was optimised through computational fluid dynamics. Positioned about 0.8 metres below the surface in two layers, they circulate water gently without creating turbulence. The result: smoother flow, minimal interference, and optimal stroke efficiency.

This difference has turned out to be significant. Olympian Sajan Prakash and national record-holder Rishabh Das describe this pool as faster than any other they've trained in. "We can really focus on our strokes and refine technical aspects here. The lane ropes are wider, and it's designed to control waves, so it's a huge advantage," says Sajan, adding that a pre-event month-long training camp at the same venue proved invaluable. With Myrtha supplying pools for major international competitions, they were able to train in conditions identical to those at the World Championships and the Olympics.

So where does the edge in performance truly come from?

Hakim points to the pool's depth. "The pool is two metres deep on both sides and slopes into a larger section that's three metres deep," he



explains. "Deeper pools tend to have less rebound from the floor and contribute slightly to performance." Combined with world-class starting blocks, wave-absorbing lane lines, and four-sided overflow gutters, the design ensures every element enhances speed and consistency.

Versatility, too, is integral to the pool's design. The 1.5-metre mobile wall allows the 50-metre pool to be divided into two 25-metre sections for short-course events or simultaneous activities such as water polo and training. "Our pools don't use tiles at all — that's one of the biggest pain points we've eliminated," Hakim shares. "Everything is PVC-laminated stainless steel, factory-laminated for strength and durability. That makes it much easier to maintain. And with European standards for water quality, we ensure swimmers always train in safe, consistent conditions."

For India's top swimmers, this pool seems to have set a new benchmark. "I've been swimming for more than 20 years and have seen how facilities have evolved in the country. Having this kind of pool in India is a huge blessing for us," says Sajan, who finished the Asian Aquatics Championships with one silver and two bronze medals. It

Swift affirmation: Sajan Prakash calls the pool at the Naranpura complex one of India's fastest — and his results at the Asian Aquatics Championships seem to agree.

ASIAN AQUATICS CHAMPIONSHIPS

turned out to be India's most successful swimming and diving campaign yet, with 13 medals in total — seven of them won by Srihari Nataraj. Hakim, understandably, must be a happy man.

Inaugurated last month, the sports complex — built at a cost of ₹825 crore — is one of India's largest, seamlessly combining Olympic-standard training infrastructure with community spaces and residential amenities. Designed to host international events — from the recently concluded Commonwealth Weightlifting Championships to the upcoming 2029 World Police and Fire Games — it also stands ready to serve as a potential venue for the 2030 Commonwealth Games and the 2036 Olympics, should India secure its bids.

The writer was at the venue on an invitation from Gujarat Sports Infrastructure Development Company Limited (GSID).